Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

- Document version: 1.0.0-beta, April-2026
- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1.
- Distributed at:
  https://github.com/wrwetzel/Helix-Cheat-Sheet
  https://helix.wrwetzel.com

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1.1 Definitions

- **file** - the actual data on storage device
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor, not just the selection
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping

1.2 Typographic Conventions

- `word` - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- `WORD` - whitespace-delimited
- `Ctrl-c` - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- `Alt-c` - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- `␣c` is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars `<regex>`, `<file>` and `<ch>` represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- `␣`, `<minus>`, and `<under>` used for clarity. `<enter>`, `<del>`, `<bksp>`, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.3 Launching

```
helix
helix <file>
helix <file1> <file2> … <file1>
helix --help
hx in some distributions or by alias
```

1.4 Basics

Editing paradigm: select first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

1.4.1 Example

```
v3wd
          v – enter select mode
          3 – select 3
          w – words
          d – delete
```

1.4.2 Samples

```
         wd – delete word
         xc – change line
         %y – yank entire file
```

1.5 Modes

As used in Helix documentation.

```
          : – command
          i – insert
          v – select or extend
          z – view - change view preserving selection
          g – goto
          m – match
     Ctrl-w – window
          ␣ – space
       [, ] – unimpaired
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Essentials

```
      u / U – undo / redo change in linear history
Alt-u / Alt-U – move backward / forward in tree history
  :ear / :lat – move backward / forward in history by step count or time
                span (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
  <nn><cmd> – repeat <cmd> <nn> times
        Esc – return to normal mode
```

2.1.1 Quit

Add ! suffix to force operation.

```
       :wq – write current buffer and quit
  :wq <file> – write current buffer to <file> and quit
       :wqa – write all buffer(s) and quit
         :q – quit current buffer, exits if last
```

2.1.2 Files

```
  :o <file> – open <file> in new buffer
  :w <file> – write current buffer to <file>
 :hs <file> – open/create <file> in new horizontal split
 :vs <file> – open/create <file> in new vertical split
         ␣wf – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in horizontal split
         ␣wF – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in vertical split
          gf – open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection.
          ␣f – open file picker at LSP workspace root
          ␣F – open file picker at current working directory
          ␣g – open changed file picker
```

2.1.2.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

```
     <enter> – open selected in current view
      Ctrl-s – open selected in new horizontal split
      Ctrl-v – open selected in new vertical split
```

2.1.3 Buffers

Add ! suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

```
          :n – create new scratch buffer
         :bc – close current buffer
        :bca – close all buffers
       :bco – close all but current buffer
         :bn – next buffer
          ␣b – open buffer picker
          ga – go to last accessed/alternate buffer
          gm – go to last modified/alternate buffer
          gn – go to next buffer
          gp – go to previous buffer
```

2.1.4 Views

Ctrl-w and `␣w` are synonymous.

```
   ␣ws / ␣wv – split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
  ␣wns / ␣wnv – split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
         ␣wq – close current split
         ␣wo – close all but current split
         ␣ww – next split
   ␣wh/j/k/l – move to buffer left / up / down / right
   ␣wH/J/K/L – swap split with buffer on left / up / down / right
         ␣wt – transpose split
```

2.1.4.1 View Movement

Commands shown with `z` prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

```
           Z – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc
      zz, zc – align to center
          zt – align to top
          zb – align to bottom
          zm – align to middle horizontally
          zj – scroll down
          zk – scroll up
```

2.1.5 Help

```
       :tutor – open tutorial
          ␣? – open command palette
```

2.2 Movement

2.2.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

```
     h/j/k/l – left / up / down / right
      gh, g| – beginning of line
     <nn>g| – column <nn>
          gl – end of line
          gg – top of file
<nn>G, g<nn>g – line <nn>
          ge – bottom of file
          gw – two-char labels on words, label to go to word
          g.– to last modification in current file
          gj – down textual line
          gk – up textual line
          gs – first non-white-space char
          gt – top of screen
          gc – middle of screen
          gb – bottom of screen
```

2.2.2 By Language Server Protocol - Semantics

Requires LSP support.

```
          gd – go to definition
          gy – go to type definition
          gr – go to references
          gi – go to implementation
          ]d – next diagnostic
          [d – prior diagnostic
          ]D – last diagnostic
          [D – first diagnostic
```

2.2.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
   ]f, [f – to next, prior function
   ]t, [t – to next, prior type definition
   ]T, [T – to next, prior test
   ]a, [a – to next, prior arg
   ]c, [c – to next, prior comment
   ]g, [g – to next, prior change
   ]G, [G – to last, first change
  Alt-e – move to end of parent node in syntax tree
  Alt-b – move to start of parent node in syntax tree
```

2.2.4 By Page

```
   Ctrl-b – page up
   Ctrl-f – page down
   Ctrl-u – half page up
   Ctrl-d – half page down
```

2.3 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between anchor and cursor
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.3.1 Operations

```
       % – select whole file
  Alt-; – swap anchor and cursor
  Alt-: – selection to normal direction (cursor at end)
  Alt-o – expand selection syntax-aware
  Alt-i – shrink selection
      ; – collapse selection(s) to cursor(s)
```

2.3.2 By TextObjects

```
ma<ch> / mi<ch> – match around / inside the object indicated by <ch>
                  below:
          w / W – word / WORD
              p – paragraph
  (, [, ', etc.– specified surround pairs
              m – closest surround pair
              f – function
              t – type or class
              a – argument/parameter
              c – comment
              T – test
              g – change git hunk
```

2.3.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
  w / W – to start of next word / WORD
  e / E – to end of current word / WORD
  b / B – to start of current word / WORD
      x – current line, extend by line
      X – extend to line
  Alt-x – shrink to line bounds
     ]p – to next paragraph
     [p – to prior paragraph
```

2.3.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
  Alt-o – expand selection to parent syntax node
  Alt-i – shrink syntax tree object selection
  Alt-p – select previous sibling node in syntax tree
  Alt-n – select next sibling node in syntax tree
  Alt-a – select all sibling nodes in syntax tree
  Alt-I – select all children nodes in syntax tree
```

2.3.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
  f<ch>, F<ch> – to <ch> inclusive (find)
  t<ch>, T<ch> – to <ch> exclusive (till)
        Alt-.  – repeat last find / till
```

2.4 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

```
          v – toggle select mode
        Esc – return to normal
          ) – cycle primary selection forward
          ( – cycle primary selection backward
     Alt-,  – remove primary selection
```

2.5 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one is *primary*.

2.5.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

```
  s<regex> – matches become selections
        S – split on match
   Alt-s – split on newlines
C, Alt-C – add selection below, above
```

2.5.2 Operations

```
          & – align on primary cursor
Alt-<minus> – merge selections
Alt-<under> – merge consecutive selections
          , – remove all except primary selection
      Alt-, – remove primary selection
    ( / ) – rotate primary backwards / forwards
Alt-( / Alt-) – rotate content backward / forward
          K – keep selections matching the regex
    Alt-K – remove selections matching the regex
```

2.6 Alter Buffer Content

2.6.1 Insert

```
          i – before selection
          a – after selection
          I – at start of line
          A – at end of line
          o – add line and insert below cursor
          O – add line and insert above cursor
        Esc – end insert (return to normal)
          . – repeat last insert
```

2.6.2 Add

```
         ]␣ – newline below
         [␣ – newline above
     ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.3 Delete

```
          d – selection -> yank buf, delete selection
      Alt-d – delete, no save
   md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.4 Change

```
          c – selection -> yank buf, change selection
      Alt-c – change, no save
          = – format by LSP
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.6.5 Indent Lines

```
          > – Indent line(s) containing selection
          < – Undent line(s) containing selection
```

2.6.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

```
          ~ – change case
          ` – set lowercase
      Alt-` – set uppercase
```

2.6.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

```
  ␣c, Ctrl-c – Toggle comment
          ␣C – Toggle block comment
     ␣Alt-C – Toggle line comment
```

2.6.8 Increment / Decrement

```
   Ctrl-a – increment the selected number
   Ctrl-x – decrement the selected number
```

2.6.9 Miscellaneous

```
          J – join lines in a selection
      Alt-J – join lines inside selection and select the inserted space
    <under> – trim whitespace from selection
```

2.7 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
          y – selection -> yank buf
          p – paste yank buf after the cursor
          P – paste yank buf before the cursor
         ␣y – yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
         ␣Y – yank main selection -> system clipboard
  ␣p / ␣P – paste clipboard after / before selections(s)
         ␣R – replace selection(s) with clipboard
      r<ch> – replace selection with <ch>
          R – replace selection with yank buf
          " – select register to yank to or paste from
```

2.8 Search

```
   /<regex> – search forward for regex
  ?<regex> – search backward for regex
      n, N – next, previous match
         * – search for current selection, respect word boundaries
    Alt-* – search for current selection
```

2.9 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
   "<ch> – change to reg <ch>
"<ch>y – yank into reg <ch>
"<ch>p – paste from reg <ch>
"<ch>R – replace with reg <ch>
```

2.10 Macros

```
   "<ch>Q – toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
   "<ch>q – play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.11 Jumplists

```
   Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist
   Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist
   Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist
       ␣j – open jumplist picker
```

2.12 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
          mm – go to matching delim
     mi<ch> – match inside delim <ch>
     ma<ch> – match around delim <ch>
     ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
     md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.13 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
          | – replace selection(s) with output
      Alt-| – ignore output
          ! – insert output before each selection(s)
      Alt-! – append output after each selection(s)
          $ – keep selection(s) where command returned 0
```

2.14 Approaching an IDE

```
         ␣G – debug - experimental
         ␣k – show documentation for item under cursor
         ␣s – open document symbol picker
         ␣S – open workspace symbol picker
         ␣d – open document diagnostics picker
         ␣D – open workspace diagnostics picker
         ␣r – rename symbol
         ␣a – apply code action
         ␣h – select symbol references for symbol under cursor
```

2.15 Editor Configuration

```
     :config-open – open the config file
:config-open-workspace – open the workspace config file
     :config-reload – reload the config file
```

2.16 Miscellaneous

```
         ␣' – open last picker
         ␣/ – open global search in workspace folder picker
```

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

```
                 Ctrl-s – commit undo checkpoint
                 Ctrl-x – autocomplete
                 Ctrl-r – insert a register content
       Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp> – delete previous word
            Alt-d, Alt-<del> – delete next word
                 Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
                 Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-<bksp> – delete previous char
             Ctrl-d, <del> – delete next char
             Ctrl-j, <enter> – insert new line

<Up> <Down> <Left> <Right> – usual meaning but discouraged
<PageUp> <PageDown> <Home>
                    <End>
```

3.2 Command Line Editing

```
          Esc, Ctrl-c – close prompt
              <enter> – open selected
                <tab> – select next completion item
            <backtab> – select previous completion item
                 Alt-b – backward a word
                 Ctrl-b – backward a char
                 Alt-f – forward a word
                 Ctrl-f – forward a char
                 Ctrl-e – to prompt end
                 Ctrl-a – to prompt start
       Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp> – delete previous word
        Alt-d, Ctrl-<del> – delete next word
                 Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
                 Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
            <bksp>, Ctrl-h – delete previous char
             <del>, Ctrl-d – delete next char
                 Ctrl-s – insert a word under doc cursor (may be
                          changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
                 Ctrl-p – select previous history
                 Ctrl-n – select next history
                 Ctrl-r – insert the content of the register selected
                          by following input char
```

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

```
     Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up> – previous entry
           <tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down> – next entry
                         <Home> – to first entry
                          <End> – to last entry
                Ctrl-u, <PageUp> – page up
              Ctrl-d, <PageDown> – page down
                       <enter> – open selected
                  Alt-<enter> – open selected in the background without
                                closing the picker
                       Ctrl-s – open horizontally
                       Ctrl-v – open vertically
                       Ctrl-t – toggle preview
                  Esc, Ctrl-c – close picker
```

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

```
   Ctrl-u – scroll up
   Ctrl-d – scroll down
```

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

```
     Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p – previous entry
           Tab, Ctrl-n – next entry
              <enter> – close menu and accept completion
              Ctrl-c – close menu and reject completion
```

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

```
   Alt-p – previous signature
   Alt-n – next signature
```